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The Communication Routine of Retail Clothing Purchase

All retail purchases follow a routine. Ordering a burger at a fast food restaurant is similar to buying a pack of cigarettes at a convenience store. Retail interactions have to follow routine. Customers want something and stores want to sell it. Therefore, at the highest level, all retail purchases follow the same routine. However, due to complexity of social interaction, no purchase is exactly like another. This paper considers the patterns of retail clothing purchases. I seek to prove that despite the overt differences between many different purchases, the routines remain the same.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Harold Garfinkel's experiments in breaching the congruency of relevancies are important in the study of any routine. For each group of actions that form a routine, there is an inverse group of actions that breach that routine. In an experiment Garfinkel conducted, the conspirator was instructed to strike up an ordinary conversation and then insist that the other party continue to clarify any statement they make. One example of this would be if someone said they had a sandwich, the conspirator would ask, "What do you mean, you had a sandwich?" The result of conducting the breaching experiments was proving that deviation from a normal routine will result in unrest and confusion (Garfinkel 1963). While the degree of confusion is generally less in retail clothing purchase, there are minor breaches of standard routine that result in an alternative set of

processes to complete the purchase. However, not all the importance of a social interaction is based on the routine.

Eye gaze is an important part of any face-to-face social interaction. Therefore, gaze is an important part of retail purchase interaction. Mutual gaze can establish the intention to interact. Looking downward to avoid the glance of another person or refusing to establish eye-contact are both methods to avoid interaction. This aversive action, can create a negative first impression, or set the tone for an entire interaction sequence. On many occasions, the difference between being able to hear something and being able to see something can completely change the situation (Simmel 1921). For this reason, gaze must be examined as a factor in any social interaction, and is especially useful as a diagnostic tool in analyzing retail purchase interactions. Just as eye gaze is important in social interactions, understanding the required information for each type of interaction is equally important.

Interacting in the public realm encompasses many unique sequences. In order to properly process an interaction within this environment, structure must be designed. This is one of the issues that Loftland addresses in *A world of strangers*. One of the primary observations Loftland makes is that the particular interaction determines how much information participants need about one another. An interaction involving the invitation of a stranger into one's home creates an expectancy of sharing more information between participants (Loftland 1973). In contrast, an interaction in the public forum, such as a retail purchase, requires, and expects, a much lesser degree of information sharing. The participants understand the roles assigned to each other and proceed with the appropriate interactional sequence. For instance, the customer understands it is their role to present

the items they wish to purchase and pay for, and the cashier understands their role is to facilitate the purchase of the items.

Interactions in the public forum have another unique quality, mutual face engagement. Erving Goffman offers a robust explanation:

“Face engagements comprise all those instances of two or more participants in a situation joining each other openly in maintaining a single focus of cognitive and visual attention – what is sensed as a single *mutual activity*, entailing preferential communication rights”(Goffman 1963, pp. 89).

The *mutual activity* that is referred to can be chatting, sexual relations, debate, and most notable to the discussion of this paper: personal servicing such as retail purchase. The author finds that no matter what the situation, the parties involved mutually engage each other in the interest of completing a known task (ibid.).

The environment in which any social interaction takes place is integral to the outcome. In *The Terrazzo Jungle*, Gladwell dives into the fifty-year life of the American mall. The article reveals that the design of a successful mall is both meticulous and scientific. Creating the right flow of pedestrian traffic, placement of stores, aesthetic fixtures, and lighting allow the function of the mall to be carried out (Gladwell 2004). The mall can be interpreted as a great generalization of any purposely designed area of interaction. Just as a mall is designed to allow people to shop many open stores in one location, a retail purchase counter should be designed to allow many people make purchases.

ANALYSIS

I. ALTERNATIVE SEQUENCES

A retail clothing purchase, in the simplest sense, should be a very basic process. Ideally, the customer approaches with items, the cashier rings up those items and receives payment, and the customer leaves with the purchased items. However, it is rare that interactions occur this simply in everyday life. In reality, there are frequent disruptions of this expected system that occur. Many factors are to blame for these frequent diversions. The level of complexity for a retail clothing purchase could be considered greater than many other forms of retail purchase. A less strictly defined site of interaction allows more opportunity to stray from the norm. Cashiers of a lower skill level then would be found in a highly specialized retail environment may also complicate the process. The uniqueness of each interaction is a combination of many factors, and explains why observable breaches are different in each circumstance yet frequent nonetheless.

Observation I:

[Girl about 15 years of age approaches transaction counter.]

[Cashier is standing behind the counter, in front of a register.]

[Girl has many items in her hands but does not place any of them on the counter but holds out one of the items toward the Cashier.]

(Girl) *"Is this on sale?"*

(Cashier) *"No, sorry that's not."*

[Girl places two items on the counter, hands the remained to the cashier.]

[Cashier takes the items, turns around, and places them on the back counter. Then turns back to the register and begins to scan the two items.]

(Cashier) *"Fifty-one dollars please, cash, check, or credit?"*

[Girl hands over some money, and receives her change from the cashier.]

[Cashier bags the two items and hands the bag to the girl along with a printed receipt.]

[Girl takes the bag and looks over the receipt for about 20 seconds, then walks away from the transaction counter.]

In this observation, there is one noticeable disruption of the simplistic retail purchase outline mentioned earlier. The trigger is the customers query about the purported sales items. Ideally, the price of the items would be clearly indicated, alleviating this action. This was not the case, and created a tangential interaction from the actual purchase. However, once this aside-interaction was completed, the retail purchase followed the simplistic form. One point of contention may have come after the girl examined the receipt; had she taken issue with what she saw, there could have been further interaction. Yet this was not the case, so there was no further breach of the normal sequence.

Observation II:

[Customer approaches sales counter and places items on it.]

[There are no employees stationed at any of the registers, behind the counter, or in the transaction room.]

[Customer waits by the counter, looking in each direction numerous times]

[Store Floor Manager walks into transaction room and observes customer standing at counter, walks behind counter and begins the transaction. Midway through the required scanning and summing of the articles, another employee returns to their post as cashier. The manager hands the transaction over to the cashier who finishes the interaction with the customer, finally handing a bag with the purchased items to the customer.]

[Customer leaves the transaction area.]

In this observation, there are two separate and distinct tangents to the basic retail purchase formula. The first occurs before the transaction even begins, in that no cashier or employee is present at the purchase area. The customer, looking around for help, had obviously noticed this deflection from standard practice. When the manager begins the transaction, it is then briefly follows the normal course. The second deflection occurs when the transaction is transferred from the manager to the cashier. Although there was no noticeable reaction from the customer when this occurred, the standard routine was interrupted. This is useful in showing that although breaches commonly occur in retail transactions; they do not always taint or complicate the process.

II. GAZE

In the routine of retail clothing purchase, gaze is an easily observable feature. In a typical interaction, gaze is used to establish a mutual connection. In the case of retail clothing purchase, this connection occurs between the customer, and the salesperson or cashier. It signifies that both parties are committed to the transaction. Mutual gaze for the purpose of accomplishing a task is essentially status-quo in a typical purchase. Deflection from this form of status-quo is noticeable in some transactions.

Observation III:

[A young woman, perhaps in her early twenties, approaches the counter with numerous pairs of underwear (underwear happened to be on sale, with five pairs constituting a special price).]

[There is one male worker behind the counter.]

[The woman stands a few feet away and looks down the counter away from the male employee, toward two unoccupied register areas. After about five seconds,

the girl steps up to the counter in front of the male employee and places her underwear down.]

[The cashier scans and bags each of the items.]

[The woman stands back from the counter, looking down, and shifting her weight from foot to foot.]

[The cashier accepts payment, places the receipt in the bag, and hands it to the woman.]

[Woman quickly reaches over the counter and prematurely takes the bag from the cashier. Her eyes remain focused on the bag and not the employee.]

In this observation, the aversion of gaze is very telling of the path the transaction will follow. The aversion of a gaze is often indicative of shame or embarrassment (Simmel 1921). It can be surmised by the consistent lack of eye gaze exhibited by the female customer, that she was ashamed to be purchasing underwear through a male employee. We might infer that she would have preferred to purchase these items from a female cashier instead, hence the pause before approaching the counter to look for alternate cashiers. Additionally, the lack of eye gaze throughout the transaction caused a noticeable hastening of the process, shown clearly in the customer's eagerness to snatch the bag out of the cashier's hand. Eye gaze is essential to mutual interaction; but it is the lack of this gaze that is most noticeable and indicative of a skewed sales experience.

III. THE PUBLIC ORDER

Public order is an important element of any structured social interaction. In fact, it is the structure of a routine interaction that both parties acknowledge that makes it possible. In order for a retail clothing purchase interaction to be successful or efficient, both parties must be aware of the routine. The typical structure of a retail clothing

purchase is as follows: First, the customer must bring the item they wish to purchase to the cashier. Second, the cashier must ring up the item and request payment. Third, the customer must surrender payment. Fourth and finally, the cashier must return the purchased goods to the customer. These four steps are essentially the foundation to a retail clothing purchase. Each step must be completed for the transaction to be successful. Although the order in which the steps are accomplished does not have to be sequential, it was always completed this way in my observations.

Observation IV:

[Multiple employees are congregating in the transaction area.]

[A customer approaches the counter, and the three employees facing away from the customer continue to talk.]

Customer: "Excuse me?"

[After some confusion among the employees, one was designated to service the customer. The items were handed from customer to cashier who rang them up.]

Cashier: "Cash, check, or credit card?"

[Customer hands a credit card to the cashier]

[Cashier returns card]

Cashier: "You can swipe it through that machine right there."

[Customer completes the credit card process on the station]

[Cashier folds and bags all of the purchased items. Hands the receipt and the bag, to the customer.]

In this example the basic four steps of retail clothing purchase were accomplished. However, some of the steps were complicated and required modifications to the usual routine. For instance, there was not a designated cashier at the start of the interaction, so the customer could not easily initiate the transaction. Once the cashier was decided and items handed over, the first step was accomplished. The second step of

scanning the items was completed without distraction in this example. The third stage of the transaction, acceptance of payment, was the starting point of an additional interactional sequence. The customer was unaware that they would process the credit card themselves and therefore handed it to the cashier, who had to explain the situation. This did not break the process of the transaction, and shows the dynamic nature of the interaction; exceptions do arise and must be handled in a way as to not destroy the required sequence of events. Once this particular exception was remedied, the transaction was completed by the cashier surrendering the purchased goods to the customer.

Observation V:

[Customer at the counter hands their items directly to the cashier.]

[Cashier puts each item on the counter and scans them.]

Cashier: "How will you be paying?"

Customer: "Debit Card."

Cashier: "Okay, you just swipe it through that machine there, then type in your PIN and press enter when you're done."

[Cashier places the items in a bag and places it on the floor. Then takes the receipt when it finishes printing.]

Cashier: "Would you like the receipt in the bag?"

[Customer nods affirmative.]

[Cashier hands bag to customer.]

[Customer leaves transaction counter.]

In this observation, as with the previous one, the normal sequence was completed in standard order. It also featured additional interaction elements much like the earlier observation. During the payment step of the transaction process, the customer indicated verbally that they would be using a debit card, in contrast to the non-verbal

communication used by the credit card customer in the first observation. Although this was a different reaction, it still required a sub-interaction, in the form of debit card instructions from the cashier. Another sub-interaction occurred in the fourth step of the process when the cashier asked if the customer would like the receipt placed in the bag. This required a response from the customer which was essential to the completion of this particular transaction but not essential to the overall structure of retail clothing purchase. Again, this shows the dynamic nature of each situation and enforces the idea that both parties involved must be adaptive to any alterations in the standard routine.

IV. SPACE AND OBJECTS

Highly specific interaction locations, such as that of a retail clothing purchase area, are deliberately designed to facilitate the intended interaction. In the case of retail clothing purchases, the sales counter area is designed to efficiently and effectively accomplish a transaction. In the retail clothing store I observed, the purchase point consists of a counter approximately 10 feet long, 4 feet tall and 3 feet deep. There are three registers placed equidistant on the counter, and another counter opposite the registers where two theft-sensor removing stations are kept. There may be up to three clerks at a time, and there is no separation of space between them. The layout of the purchase point and lack of obstructions, accoutrements, or anything non-essential to the task at hand, proves that this location is highly specific to one form of interaction.

In each of the five observations I made, the purchase point achieved its goal. It had multiple uses but all accomplished the goal of completing a purchase successfully. For the customer, the counter served as a place to lay items for the cashier to retrieve. It

also held a personal credit card transaction machine in an easily accessible location if it was needed. For the cashier, the front counter offered a place to lay items while they were being scanned, and the back counter served as an area to place items that needed to have security sensors removed before being bagged. Additionally, the presence of multiple cash registers would facilitate three simultaneous transactions with no interference. The only area of possible interference would be the rear counter only having two security tag removing devices. If there were three cashiers who needed to remove sensors at the same time, this might create a bottleneck or overlap issue, however this was never an issue in any of my observations.

In summary, the layout and location of elements within the purchase point area are clear and well defined. Additionally, they are well suited to efficiently complete retail clothing purchases. This intelligent design is what allows the standard purchase routine to be carried out. If the transaction area were less efficient, the standard transaction format may be disrupted causing complications in the process.

CONCLUSION

There is observable routine in each retail clothing purchase. The same elements are repeated each time, in varying ways. Although the specifics of each transaction may vary, such as the number of items, the method of payment, or the words exchanged between customer and cashier, the routine is essentially the same. On one level, each transaction is successful due to mutual eye gaze and cooperation in completing the task. However, the task can be completed without mutual eye gaze, but results in a more convoluted transaction routine. Understanding of the expected order of each transaction is

essential to their success. Both parties, customer and cashier, must understand what steps need to be completed and what their roles in those steps must be. If a complication arises it must be assessed and processed before the associated step can be completed. Therefore, each retail clothing purchase is a dynamic interaction set within a basic and simplistic framework. These interactions are assisted by the highly task-specific spatial orientation of a purchase point. The area is organized in such a way that each party has access to the elements they need to successfully complete the transaction with minimal complication. For all of these reasons we can observe that there is routine social interaction in each retail clothing purchase.

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